

A CANTABRIGIAN LANE DISPUTE

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Based on an original story by
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INT. DINGY ROOM - NIGHT

ED and JEREMY sit on a couch playing Fortnite. FourLoko cans are on the table in front of them.

A pop up shows up on the screen.

JEREMY
What the hell is this?

ED
They're using AI to...make Fortnite better?

They let out a collective groan.

JEREMY
It's a fucking video game what do they need AI for?

ED
I really don't know.

JEREMY
I don't even want to play anymore.
Why is nothing safe from AI
bullshit?

They toss their controllers aside.

JEREMY (CONT'D)
What now?

ED
Maybe it's Loko time.

Ed looks towards the unopened FourLokos. Jeremy shrugs.

JEREMY
Hey, it's not like either of us
have work tomorrow.

They reach for the drinks.

CUT TO:

INT. DINGY ROOM - MORNING

A phone is buzzing. Jeremy's eyes open against his will. He groans and looks over at his phone. It's an unknown number. He's puzzled, but answers it anyways.

JEREMY

Hello?

BORIS

Yes, is this Jeremy?

JEREMY

Uh, yeah, who's this?

BORIS

This is Boris. I'm just calling to confirm your scheduled interview later today?

JEREMY

Interview?

BORIS

Well, yes, you didn't think we'd just hand you the positions did you?

JEREMY

Uh, no. Of course not. What time was it again?

BORIS

Two pm. And Ed will be in attendance as well?

Jeremy looks over at Ed. Ed, just woken up, looks back perplexed.

JEREMY

Uh, yeah. He'll be there.

BORIS

Ok. I look forward to meeting both of you!

Boris hangs up.

ED

Who was that?

JEREMY

I don't know but I think he wants to give us jobs. We have an interview at two.

ED

Oh god really? How much FourLoko did we drink last night?

He looks over at his laptop and turns it on. LinkedIn is pulled.

ED (CONT'D)

I guess we applied to this...thing.

JEREMY

What is it?

ED

I don't really know. Some AI data company thing.

JEREMY

We're not qualified for that. What does it say the qualifications are?

ED

It doesn't say.

JEREMY

I don't want to do some AI bullshit man.

ED

Yeah me either.

He looks around him at the trash and filth of their one room apartment.

JEREMY

Wait, how much does it pay?

ED

Eighty-thousand dollars a year.

They both go silent. Then suddenly they're in a frenzy, tossing on fresh clothes and brushing their teeth and so on.

EXT. STREET - DAY

Ed and Jeremy bike to the job interview.

INT. AI OFFICE - DAY

Ed and Jeremy sit behind a desk. In front of them is BORIS. Behind him is a CLTDM slideshow.

BORIS

So, what's your dream job?

ED

Well It's always been my dream to have a job, sir.

BORIS

Uh, sure. And you?

JEREMY

Uh, I've always wanted to change the world. And this seems like just the place to do that.

BORIS

You're just going to be doing some basic server maintenance. You know that right?

JEREMY

Uh, yeah. I know that. Server maintenance has just always interested me in it's potential to uh...maintain.

BORIS

Well, I'm glad to hear that. Here at CLTDM we're taking a new approach to AI and it's role in many things in the public sphere. From parks and buses to benches and bike lanes, we believe that AI can make everything better. We're also working on developing revolutionary AI-powered kitchen appliances and shoes!

He points to a picture on a slideshow of the worst buses, kitchen appliances, benches, and shoes you've ever seen. Ed and Jeremy look at each other.

BORIS (CONT'D)

We've developed a highly advanced Artificial Intelligence called ALIGN that is more powerful and advanced than any of our competitor's. Our current project is a mass reconsideration of the bike lanes in the surrounding area.

Boris changes the slide to show a bike lane diagram.

BORIS (CONT'D)

ALIGN is helping us to build the safest and most efficient roads that we can.

ED

Wow, this is all very impressive,
sir!

Boris smiles.

BORIS

Look, usually with these types of
positions, you're not supposed to
give them out on the spot. But I
think you two might be just what
this position calls for. So what do
you say?

JEREMY

So we got the job?

BORIS

You got the job! You can start
tomorrow!

EXT. SIDEWALK - DAY

Jeremy is waiting on the sidewalk. Ed pulls up in the
SmartCar, top down. He's eating Pad Thai and wearing
sunglasses and a visor.

JEREMY

Oh no, what did you do?

ED

Hey this thing moves! And it's
pennies to us now!

JEREMY

I kind of liked biking to work. And
we haven't even worked a full day
yet. Are you sure this was a good
idea?

ED

I got it with Klarna man. I'm never
gonna have to pay it back anyways.
C'mon, we're gonna be late.

Jeremy shakes his head but hops in the car and they speed
away.

INT. OFFICE BUILDING - DAY

The elevator opens and Jeremy and Ed step out. JEFF is
waiting for them.

JEFF
You must be Ed and Jeremy!

JEREMY
Yeah that's us. I'm Jeremy.

ED
Ed. Nice to meet you.

They shake hands.

JEFF
I'm Jeff. I'm also on the ALIGN team. Boris said I'm in charge of giving you the rundown this morning.

They walk into a room of desks. Jeff points at two.

JEFF (CONT'D)
This is where you'll be working.

Ed and Jeremy sit down at their respective desks, and Jeff helps them get logged on.

JEFF (CONT'D)
So basically what you're going to be doing is this.

On Ed's screen is a captcha that says "click all squares with bicycles". Jeff clicks the bikes. The computer makes a ding sound, and a new captcha appears.

JEFF (CONT'D)
Just click all the bicycles. Here, give it a try.

Ed successfully clicks all the bikes.

ED
That's it?

JEFF
That's it. Not a bad gig, right?

ED
No, not at all.

He smiles and leans back in his chair.

INT. OFFICE BUILDING - DAY

A few hours later. Ed and Jeremy are hard at work on their captchas.

ED
I'm gonna run to the kitchen, you
want anything?

JEREMY
No thanks.

Ed stands up and heads to the kitchen. On his return he notices some stuff on Jeff's desk. It's a picture of Jeff dunking, and a picture of Jeff hoisting a trophy.

ED
You a big basketball guy?

JEFF
I was. But that was all before...

FLASHBACK TO:

INT. BASKETBALL COURT

Jeff is dunking on guys and hitting step backs left right and center. He's unstoppable.

After the game, Jeff is conversing with an NBA SCOUT.

SCOUT
Just keep your head on your
shoulders and you should go top
twenty. I don't see you falling any
farther than that.

JEFF (V.O.)
It was all going so well, until one
day I felt a pain in my shoulder
during a game...

Jeff is playing basketball, but suddenly stops dribbling, clutching at his shoulder.

JEFF (V.O.)
The doctor said my shoulder was at
risk of a sever dislocation as a
result of playing on the monkey
bars too much as a child, but that
I would be fine and able to keep
playing basketball as long as I
didn't dunk anymore.

Jeff is playing basketball again.

JEFF

But I just couldn't help myself.
Dunking on guys brought me more joy
than anything in the world. I
couldn't help myself.

He violently dunks on a guy's head. As he hangs on the rim,
his shoulder comes out and he goes falling to the floor.

JEFF (V.O.)

The doctors said they'd never seen
anything like it. I dislodged my
shoulder so bad they had to hook it
up to an F-150 to pull it back in.
I could never play the same again.

INT. OFFICE BUILDING - DAY

JEFF

And now I work here.

ED

I'm sorry man.

JEREMY

Yeah, that sucks.

JEFF

Don't worry about it. This pays
well doesn't it? I'm not sure what
else I'd be doing with my life
anyways.

Also on Jeff's desk is a small painting.

ED

Did you paint that?

JEFF

Yeah, it's just something I do on
the side since I stopped playing
basketball.

Boris comes into the room.

BORIS

C'mon now guys, back to work. This
AI isn't gonna generate itself!

Ed heads back to his seat, taking one last look at the
picture of Jeff dunking as he does so.

INT. SMART CAR - NIGHT

Ed and Jeremy are heading home in the Smart Car.

ED

If every day's that easy this job's
gonna be a blast.

JEREMY

I can't believe that's all they
have us doing.

In front of them is a cyclist, EDGAR.

EXT. STREET - NIGHT

He whistles to himself as he bikes along. Suddenly, a car
pulls out in front of him, and he has to slam on his brakes
to avoid a collision.

Edgar heads straight for the guy. The DRIVER waves
apologetically. Edgar smiles and feigns forgiveness, but
motions for the driver to put down his window. The Driver
does.

DRIVER

I'm very sorry I just didn't-

Edgar reaches through the open window and grabs the guy by
the shirt collar and draws a gun and points it at him.

INT. SMARTCAR - NIGHT

Ed and Jeremy witness Edgar draw the gun.

JEREMY

Oh fuck. Let's get out of here.

The Driver speeds off. Edgar turns and sees Ed and Jeremy,
and starts running towards them.

ED

Oh fuck oh fuck.

Ed frantically tries to put the car in reverse, but it's not
working.

JEREMY

What's wrong? Reverse out of here!

ED
It won't go! I think it's because I
spilled all that Pad Thai in it
earlier.

The gear console is full of noodles.

JEREMY
You what?

Suddenly, the sound of a gun cocking as a pistol is pressed
to the back of Ed's head.

EDGAR
Who are you two? Why are you
watching me?

Suddenly, he notices Ed's work tag around his neck.

EDGAR (CONT'D)
You guys work for CLTDM?

ED
Yes but today was our first day.

EDGAR
What department?

ED
What?

EDGAR
I said what department!?

He pushes the gun into Ed's head.

ED
ALIGN! We work in ALIGN.

Edgar muses on this for a moment.

EDGAR
Let me in.

ED
What?

EDGAR
I said let me in the car.

ED
But there's only two seats?

INT. SMART CAR - NIGHT

Edgar sits awkwardly in the trunk still holding the gun to Ed's head.

EDGAR
Slow down! Fucking driver scum.

Ed and Jeremy look at each other.

EDGAR (CONT'D)
I wasn't really going to kill that guy you know. I just think that drivers deserve to feel a minutia of the fear they make bikers feel on a daily fucking basis once in a while.

Ed and Jeremy stay silent as they pull up to their house.

EDGAR (CONT'D)
This is it?

Ed nods.

EDGAR (CONT'D)
Come on. Let's go up.

INT. DINGY ROOM - NIGHT

Edgar sits on a couch facing Ed and Jeremy, still holding the gun at them.

EDGAR
Captchas!? They just have you doing Captchas all day?

JEREMY
Yeah that was it.

Edgar shakes his head.

EDGAR
You, tie him up.

He motions from Ed to Jeremy.

ED
What?

EDGAR
Tie him up. Use these.

He tosses Ed some ropes.

ED
I'm not going to-

Edgar points the gun at him.

ED (CONT'D)
Okay okay.

He ties Jeremy up to a chair.

Edgar keeps the gun pointed at Jeremy.

ED (CONT'D)
Why are you doing this?

EDGAR
You're going to get something for
me, or he's going to die.

ED
What? What do you want?

EDGAR
You're going to go back to CLTDM,
log onto the main ALIGN computer
and plug this in.

He holds up a thumb drive.

EDGAR (CONT'D)
This drive is coded with a process
to extract what I need. Once it
finishes downloading, bring it back
here and you'll never see me again.
You think you can handle that?

ED
Yeah, I can handle that.

He takes the thumb drive.

EDGAR
Do you two have any idea what CLTDM
actually does? Do you know what
you're actually working on in that
office?

JEREMY
Uhh, like data...and stuff.

Edgar shakes his head.

EDGAR

You two have no fucking idea about anything. CLDTM is attempting to eliminate all bike lanes.

ED

No, they're just trying to make them better.

EDGAR

That's what they told you huh? Look.

He pulls out two maps of a town. He points to the first map.

EDGAR (CONT'D)

This is a map of Cambridgetown, Wyoming before CLTDM moved in. More bike lanes than 95% of small cities in the US.

He points to the second map.

EDGAR (CONT'D)

This is after five years of CLTDM. They're ALL gone. There isn't a bike lane left. And they're going to do the same thing here.

Ed and Jeremy look at each other.

EDGAR (CONT'D)

Look, you don't have to believe me. You just have to do it or he dies.

Ed is just standing there.

EDGAR (CONT'D)

Well get going. Bring back that drive with what I need and you guys can make it out of this in one piece.

EXT. OFFICE BUILDING - LATE NIGHT

Ed looks around him as he scans his work ID and enters the building.

INT. OFFICE BUILDING - NIGHT

Ed steps out of the elevator into the office.

He walks through the halls until he reaches an important looking computer.

He scans his ID again to enter the room.

He sits down at the computer and turns it on. Then he pulls out the thumb drive Edgar gave them and plugs it into the computer.

It's immediately starts a downloading process. It's not going very fast.

Suddenly, footsteps can be heard approaching. Ed swings around, panicked. The door swings open and in the door way is...Jeff.

JEFF

Ed? What are you doing here?

Ed steps in front of the computer screen to hide it.

ED

Just putting in some overtime. What are YOU doing?

JEFF

I always work late. It's...sort of all I've got going for me right now.

ED

What about the painting?

JEFF

Yeah, I just don't have the time, you know?

Jeff looks around.

JEFF (CONT'D)

Wait, but you don't work in this office. Why are you on the main computer?

ED

Just taking care of some stuff Boris wanted me to do.

Jeff is suspicious. Somewhere else in the office, a different, louder noise sounds.

ED (CONT'D)

What was that?

JEFF

I don't know. But what are you doing? I didn't hear anything about any special work on the main computer.

He approaches Ed and the computer.

ED

Oh, no, you wouldn't have been told about-

But he pushes Ed aside and comes face to face with the download progress.

JEFF

You're...downloading the entire schematics? You're not allowed to do that!

ED

Jeff wait I can explain.

JEFF

It better be a damn good explanation.

ED

What if I told you that CLTDM is not what you think it is? That it's getting rid of bike lanes, not making them better?

Jeff hesitates.

JEFF

I already know.

ED

Wait, all that's true? And you know about it and still work here?

JEFF

It pays well. It's only for a little while, just until I can figure something else out.

A loud bang is heard in the hallway outside.

ED

Is someone else working late tonight?

JEFF

No, they're not supposed to be.

Loud footsteps approach the door.

JEFF (CONT'D)

Hello?

The door is flung open and in bursts an ALIEN. It lunges at Jeff and grabs him. Ed shoulder checks it off Jeff, but it recovers quickly.

JEFF (CONT'D)

What the hell?

ALIEN

(screeches)

ED

What the fuck is that?

JEFF

I don't know. I knew about the bike lanes but I've never seen this thing.

The Alien makes a move for the computer.

ED

It's trying to stop the download!

Ed tries to stop the Alien. He fails to halt it until he decides to pick up the desk chair and swing it, knocking the Alien back. The Alien charges Ed, and starts beating him up. Ed looks to Jeff.

ED (CONT'D)

Help!

JEFF

I'm sorry but I can't betray the company.

The Alien goes to choke Ed, who grabs its wrist, barely holding it off.

ED

Yes you can. It's never the wrong time to start living again. I know things have been hard and life hasn't gone how you wanted it to, but that doesn't mean you have to call it quits.

It knocks Ed's arm aside, successfully choking him. Ed looks to Jeff.

ED (CONT'D)

There's so much you still have to offer the world. Like that painting on your desk. You have so much potential.

Ed starts to fade. Jeff's face contorts, and then suddenly he grabs the chair and smacks it into the Alien, causing it to drop Ed, who gasps for air.

Jeff winds back up and throws the chair at the Alien, but his shoulder gives out and he misses badly. Jeff rushes him and tackles it to the floor.

ED (CONT'D)

Try-try to hold him off!

Jeff grapples with the Alien. Ed rushes back over to the computer to check on the download. It's almost complete.

ED (CONT'D)

C'mon, c'mon...

The computer makes a ding noise as it reaches 100%. Download complete. Ed removes the drive, puts it in his pocket and then turns around.

The Alien goes to lunge at Ed but Jeff holds it off.

JEFF

Go on, get out of here. Take down CLTDM.

ED

Are you sure?

Jeff nods.

The Alien breaks free from Jeff and again lunges for Ed and the drive but Jeff holds it back at the last moment with his busted arm. The Alien then turns back to attack Jeff, and Ed leaves the room. Jeff closes the door behind him. Ed runs down the hallway, the sounds of the scuffle echoing in his ears. He brushes aside a tear.

EXT. PARKING LOT - NIGHT

Ed jumps in and starts the Smart Car. The Alien bursts out of the front of the office building. Ed puts it in drive and speeds off.

INT. DINGY ROOM - NIGHT

Ed enters the room. Edgar is waiting for him, gun still pointed at Jeremy.

EDGAR
You got it?

Ed hands it over.

ED
Yeah.

JEREMY
Oh thank god.

Edgar snatches it from him and plugs it into his computer.

ED
You didn't say anything about a
fucking Alien!

EDGAR
You mean Align?

ED
No not Align, Alien! An Alien tried
to kill me when I tried to download
the schematics?

EDGAR
Very funny.

ED
I'm not joking!

Edgar's eyes go wide.

EDGAR
There was an actual Alien in there?

ED
Well it sure as hell wasn't a
normal ass guy!

EDGAR
Fuck, this thing might go deeper
than I thought.

ED
Yeah whatever. Can I untie him now?

He motions to Jeremy.

JEREMY

Yeah can he untie me now?

EDGAR

Yeah sure. I'm sending the kill code back into the AI.

Ed goes over and unties Jeremy.

JEREMY

Kill code?

EDGAR

It was written in by a rogue engineer who knew what CLTDM was trying to do. It's gonna make the AI cannibalize itself.

JEREMY

It's going to kill the AI? So we won't have jobs? You didn't tell us that!

EDGAR

Well, it's not like you had a choice. Besides, a lot of good cyclists died to make this possible.

ED

And one great painter.

JEREMY

What?

ED

Jeff...the Alien, it...it killed him.

JEREMY

No! He can't be-

BANG!

The wall bursts open in a cloud of drywall dust. Everyone coughs as the air clears. Maniacal laughter fills the silence.

Standing before them is Boris. He points at Edgar.

BORIS

It was so easy. The higher ups didn't want to let me try it. They thought it was too risky.

(MORE)

BORIS (CONT'D)

But I knew you wouldn't be able to resist trying to corrupt a couple of idiots, and that they would lead me right to you.

JEREMY

What?

Edgar recovers from the blast and his eyes narrow.

EDGAR

You...

He whips a piece of drywall at Boris, who catches it and turns it to dust in his grasp.

BORIS

I've been looking for you for a long time. You're the only one we didn't get when we slaughtered your whole operation.

EDGAR

Don't worry. It only takes one to finish the job.

He spin kicks him, but Boris is unaffected. He counter punches Edgar, sending him flying.

BORIS

I'm running on pure AI, son. The newest update.

He turns to reveal a wire running from his brain into an AI computer device on his back.

JEREMY

Eww.

ED

What the hell?

Edgar throws another object at Boris but he dodges it effortlessly.

BORIS

Your whole movement is pointless. AI will make the world better than it ever could be with just humans at the helm. My extraterrestrial friends have shown me.

He throws a punch at Edgar, who just narrowly avoids it.

BORIS (CONT'D)

Their world is perfect. Full of abundance. AI's figured everything out. But no, you just couldn't sacrifice your precious little bike lanes.

Edgar tries to punch Boris but he dodges it. He's moving really fast. Boris throws a counter punch which sends Edgar flying.

Edgar turns to Jeremy and Ed. He points at his laptop.

EDGAR

Protect the laptop. It will finish on it's own, just don't let him get to it or he'll shut it down.

Ed cautiously picks up the laptop.

Edgar types into his digital watch and bike wheels appear on his arms, and a bike helmet on his head.

He throws a bike-powered punch at Boris, which actually manages to stagger him for a second.

EDGAR (CONT'D)

Why the bike lanes? What do they have to do with any of this?

Boris grins.

BORIS

I don't even fully understand it myself. I just know that they're terrified of bikes, and won't touch down in full force where they're plentiful. Something about a resemblance to an ancient god who ruined their world.

EDGAR

I thought their world was perfect.

They trade more blows.

BORIS

It is. Now that they've disposed of the cyclist menace.

Boris grabs Edgar and rips the bike wheels off of him.

EDGAR

Get out of here!

Boris impales Edgar with his fist. Ed and Jeremy flee and hide.

INT. OTHER ROOM - NIGHT

Ed and Jeremy crouch down.

JEREMY

Fuck what are we going to do?

Boris is searching for them.

BORIS

You guys have been such good employees. Let's not ruin that streak now.

He's getting closer.

BORIS (CONT'D)

Just hand me that laptop and I'll give you a year's pay right now. Actually, make that three year's pay. All you have to do is give me that laptop.

Ed looks at the laptop. It's still executing the kill-switch.

JEREMY

Fuck man three years pay? That kind of money would change our lives.

ED

But what world would we be spending it in?

JEREMY

But our lives suck right now.

ED

Jeff sacrificed himself because he believed in a better world. He found the strength to pursue that belief. If we don't have that, then we might as well be dead. Money won't change our lives, but a pursuit of a better world might.

Jeremy thinks for a second. He sighs.

JEREMY

Maybe you're right. But how are we going to stop this guy? He's way too strong and way too fast.

Ivan's even closer.

BORIS

The human soul is limited, help us to rise above it. You will be there at the alter of the new soul's communion, I will make sure of it!

ED

Wait, he's powered by AI right?

JEREMY

Yeah, so?

ED

So we can beat him the same way we always beat AI. Just unplug him.

JEREMY

Yeah but how are we going to get to his back?

Boris comes into the room.

ED

Just like in Fortnite man. You lay down cover fire and I'll flank him.

Jeremy nods.

JEREMY

Alright. Let's do it.

He stands up and throws something at Boris, getting his attention. Ed sneaks away.

JEREMY (CONT'D)

Hey boss, that offer sounds really good but I'm going to have to decline. AI sucks.

Boris rushes him and grabs him by the throat, lifting him into the air.

BORIS

You idiot. You just fear that your imbecilic utility will vanish once AI becomes pervasive.

JEREMY

And you just fear that you'll never
have what we have. A soul. Now!
Unplug him.

Ed, who has gotten behind Boris, springs up and rips the
chord out of the back of Boris's head.

BORIS

Wait, what did you...?

He reaches behind him to feel the unplugged wire.

BORIS (CONT'D)

Oh, no. I can't-

He turns to dust, leaving his empty clothes to fall to the
floor in a heap.

ED

What the hell?

JEREMY

Wait, the computer, where is it?

They look around but it's not there. They hear the floor
creak and they both swing around. It's the Alien, holding the
laptop. They chase after him.

EXT. STREET - NIGHT

They chase the Alien into the street.

Suddenly it gets hit by a car.

Ed and Jeremy just stare, slack-jawed.

The laptop goes flying into the air, and Ed catches it.

The door of the car opens. Jeff, badly wounded, but alive, is
the driver. He steps out, clutching a wound in his side.

JEFF

That's for getting in the way of my
overtime pay.

The injured Alien stands back up. He turns to Jeremy and Ed.
Ed shows it the completed kill switch process screen.

ED

It's over. You lost.

The Alien shakes it's fist angrily and then hurriedly limps away into the distance. Jeff, Jeremy, and Ed watch him go.

JEREMY

You guys want to play some
Fortnite?

ED

No, no not really.

THE END